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Howard Levy

Howard Levy is a two time Grammy award winner, pianist, composer, and master of the diatonic harmonica. In addition to his own recordings as a leader, he was a founding member of Bela Fleck & the Flecktones, and has appeared on a lengthy list of recordings by other major artists.

Howard was interviewed via Zoom on November 11, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to start this interview today with Howard Levy. Welcome, sir, and congratulations on your career.

HL: Oh, thank you very much.

MR: I was looking at my own calendar today and thinking well all musicians have to have a calendar, whether it hangs on the refrigerator or it's in your phone. Can you describe to me what a typical month is like for you? What does your calendar look like?

HL: That's a very interesting story. I mean an old musician's joke is, "Hey man, my calendar looks like snow, you know, so – I don't have a typical month. It just all depends on what I'm up to. During the course of my life I've had so many different types of careers so sometimes I might be on tour for a month, and sometimes I might be home for a month with just like two or three gigs in Chicago because I live in the Chicago area. And I try not to overexpose myself here. You know I have a certain status I've achieved here so I try to pick my spots that make the maximum impact. And sometimes when I don't have that many actual gigs happening, those are the times that I use to compose and write. Because I just wrote my second concerto for myself. Actually I did that last year. And I deliberately left some time free where I wasn't taking – I tried to take as few gigs as possible to be able to, you know, concentrate on composing this concerto, which I knew would take, you know like total immersion. And I also just put out my musical memoirs.

MR: I saw that and I was going to bring that up. And that takes a bit of time, doesn't it?

HL: Oh man. You know I started writing some of these stories literally years ago, maybe twenty years ago, more like diary entries. Like I remember this important thing from my life and I'm going to type it out. And I put a few of them on my first website maybe even like thirty years ago. And then during the pandemic, when all of us had way too much time on our hands and you know the alternative was, you know, jump out a window somewhere or be really productive and really work on stuff. Well I did a lot of stuff during the pandemic. A lot of recording for people and I did a whole series of broadcasts from my home with a multi-camera thing and raised a whole bunch of money for the Greater Chicago Food Depository. I did a lot of stuff during the pandemic. But I also

started really seriously writing my memoir. Because when you sit around by yourself and you don't have the usual musical interaction, or even personal interaction with people, I found that I could go into my memory and just remember things cinematically, really. I remember, as I thought about it more and more, I just started remembering all these tiny details, like colors and smells and all sorts of things like that. So when we finally got the book into its final form I had to edit out probably like a good ten or fifteen of the stories. It would have just been too long.

MR: That is one of the hardest things to do, you've got a wealth of good material and something's got to go here.

HL: Yeah, yeah. It was just, the book is over 450 pages long and I just didn't want to make it any fatter than that. You know I didn't want to scare anybody.

MR: As you proceeded through the task of writing, did you find that you arrived at a place with adjectives and describing words that helped get the message across about the music you were doing? Because writing about music can be challenging and frustrating as well.

HL: Yeah. You know it's – the stories, it's a far ranging range of stories. I mean music is in all of them, but some of them are more personal experiences with music as part of it. But of course I did you know, write out some changes, you know G seven sharp nine flat thirteenth and stuff like that. I wrote those kind of things out. I mean there was some very specifically musical things and I tried not to geek out too much on some of those things. But yeah it is hard. But I think what really made it work (I hope it works) is that I really put myself back into these events and started remembering how I felt while they were happening you know, like the first gig I played with Tito Puente and stuff like that. I mean you know these are very vivid memories in my head. And there's another story of a jobbing date – do you call them casuals in New York?

MR: Yeah, we call them club dates and casuals.

HL: Club dates, that's right, club dates. And in Chicago they're called jobbing dates, where it was like this really square older guy who played like society two beat bass but hired all sorts of really, really good players, younger players, including a trumpet player who was in the AACM, to play a Christmas party for a bunch of phone company employees. And man, this guy just played so beautifully. It was unbelievable. I mean that's why it's in the book. I mean it was something that you would just never suspect happen. And every solo he took, the people stopped dancing and applauded like it was a concert. I mean this doesn't happen, as you know. So that's why there are certain stories in there that I just think are – hopefully it will show all these different sides of a musician's life. You know, and the odd jobs that I had in the beginning before I was, you know, "don't quit your day job" kind of thing, you know like before I was good enough to quit my day job, you

know. All sort of – the evolution of my musical life as it happened in all these different stages and steps.

MR: Was there a circumstance or a series of months that helped you decide that you could quit your day job?

HL: Oh yeah. When I couldn't stand dragging myself to work. One day it was like I just can't do this anymore. I can't get on the L in these work clothes and go and make waterbed frames anymore. I can't do it.

MR: You made waterbed frames?

HL: Yeah, yeah. Oh man, I was a plumber's assistant, I was a furniture mover, a house painter, I mean I did all this stuff. But the whole time of course I was working on my music and expanding my musical vocabulary and studying a lot of stuff, and teaching too. I was teaching harmonica and piano. And then at a certain point I just realized I cannot, I cannot do these two things at once. I have to just take the plunge, take a risk, and of course life was more affordable back then, and rent wasn't, you know you didn't have to pay an arm and a leg to rent an apartment in Evanston back in the '70s, and so I let go of all that stuff and plunged into it and, you know, I have to say Chicago was a very good place for me to do that.

MR: Did you start playing gigs as a pianist before the harmonica became, you know, your instrument that you became known for I guess?

HL: Well I started out on piano when I was eight. I studied classical piano at the Manhattan School of Music for four years on Saturdays, for four years. And so I was playing piano. And then I studied the pipe organ. I went to a private school that had a pipe organ. I did that for two years. I played a whole bunch of Bach with the foot pedals and the whole bit. But then I started playing rock & roll and I was in my high school rock band you know. I played the Farfisa organ and piano and I only started playing harmonica when I was 18.

MR: I wonder, this happened to me – getting in rock bands – and first I had an attitude. I mean I had been to music school and then I had an attitude, not a good one, about especially guitar players and so forth, people who were self-taught. And then – I felt like well they don't know – you know I remember asking a guitar player once, that's a great chord what is it? And he'd say it's this. Like – and they I got over it because – I wonder if you had a similar experience where you realized that these ear players had something that you wanted as well?

HL: Well I mean it's a little different for me because I started improvising when I was eight. Okay? I just started making up my own music. It was just something that I did naturally and I didn't understand where it was coming from but I would hear something and I would kind of imitate it, I mean I still do that now you know. And it was very hard for me to write out my improvisations because my musical being was really far ahead of my

ability to notate when I was eight and nine years old. I mean I could write out very rudimentary things. And my parents didn't have a tape recorder so all that stuff that I would come home from school and sit at the piano for a half hour, it's gone. I mean who knows what the heck it was. But there was one tune I wrote when I was eleven that I actually remembered and I actually still play today and I've recorded it on a few albums. But yeah, so it's a complex question because being classically trained, I mean I knew a certain amount of theory and I knew some chord names, probably up to a ninth. Maybe I asked the guitar player, "What's that chord?" "Oh it's a ninth chord." It's like, "Okay, got it." But a lot of what I did was just by intuition. And the way I learned how to play jazz was from listening to records and going to hear people play live at the Vanguard and places like that, you know, once I got into jazz, which is when I was 17 and 18, 17 I guess. And then I just immersed myself, I just – once I heard – the first jazz album I ever listened to was "Crescent." Okay? That was it. Okay.

MR: Hell of a place to start.

HL: Yeah. And my poor teenage brain was blown apart. Because I had been playing rock & roll and blues. But I hadn't started playing harmonica yet. So I heard this and I just wore the record out. I just listened over and over again, like what are these guys doing, what is it. I learned, basically I could sing a lot of what I had listened to. I listened so many times that I could sing Coltrane's solos without understanding like what they were or anything like that. And then I discovered – New York had a great – I grew up in New York – they had a great jazz radio station called WLIB and Billy Taylor was the program director. And they played all the greatest like Impulse! and Blue Note stuff and I'd write down the name of the album and I'd go to the record store and buy it. But then after I heard "Crescent" I said I want to hear these guys live but Coltrane had just passed away. And I looked around, I looked in the newspapers in New York like well what about those three other guys? Like I was just crazy about the whole thing. And I saw that Elvin was going to be playing a concert at the Museum of Modern Art sculpture garden. And so I got a few friends together and we went. So my first live jazz experience hearing jazz played live was Elvin and Roland Kirk playing together. So, you know –

MR: Two forces of nature.

HL: Oh man.

MR: I saw both those guys myself when I was like – in a way I was frightened.

HL: Yeah.

MR: By the intensity of it.

HL: Yeah. Yeah. I can understand that. I was just absolutely –you know it's different if you're in a more spacious venue but when you see – well anyway seeing Elvin, because I was trying to imagine like I'd only heard rock drumming, you know. And how – it sounds like

two guys and how is he doing that. And I just sat there with my jaw on the floor. I mean Elvin ruined me for hearing drummers. Any other drummer after that seemed like yeah, this guy's pretty good but he ain't Elvin. You know? And I went to hear Elvin as many times as I could after that. The trio with Joe Farrell and Jimmy Garrison, I got to hear that a bunch of times. And I heard Roland Kirk a whole bunch of times too at the Vanguard. Both of them. And at Slug's and various other places. And I got to hear a whole lot of other people too. Once I discovered that jazz existed and there I am growing up in New York – my parents never listened to jazz. My dad is actually a singer. He's 102, he's still alive. And my mom is 99. And they love the Metropolitan Opera and Broadway and all this classical stuff. They might have had a Benny Goodman album and they had maybe a Louis Armstrong album. But I never heard jazz in the house, even though I was an improviser. You know like I had the jazz spirit but I didn't know what the music really was. And then once I discovered what the music was I thought oh I feel at home here. This is what I want to do you know. I want to do this and how do I learn how to do this? So this band that I had with a bunch of friends, we evolved through all these different styles and then we started playing jazz together and I started writing my own tunes before I knew standards. You know I didn't come about it in any kind of orthodox way. And then when I went to Northwestern – which is how I ended up out here – I auditioned for the jazz band. And they did not have a jazz department back then, but they had a jazz band. And I wasn't in the music school but I really wanted to do this. So all the other guys were all veterans of high school jazz programs, which the school I went to didn't have a jazz program of any sort. And so I auditioned and I could swing, you know when I was eighteen. I had this feel and I could play over changes to a certain extent you know, and so I got the gig. And the band was led by Bunky Green.

MR: Oh my.

HL: And so Bunky was the first heavy jazz player that I ever got to play alongside of. And you know the first time he took his horn out and played I was just like ooh, who is this guy you know. Because at that time people really, outside of Chicago, didn't know who Bunky Green was in 1969.

MR: If you started with "Crescent" and Roland Kirk and so forth, did your tastes or listening habits go backwards?

HL: Yeah. I started listening, you know I listened a lot to that radio station and of course Coltrane, as many other people were, I was fixated on Coltrane. I mean it was like a religion for me. And for many others as well. It doesn't matter like what country you're from, if you're white or black or Muslim, Christian, Jewish, it doesn't matter. He had a transcendent message that he was broadcasting through his music that affected many people in this deeply spiritual and religious way. I mean I compare him to Bach. I really

do. Because he was so mathematical at the same time as he was so spiritual. And the supporting cast was ridiculous, I mean McCoy and Jimmy Garrison and Elvin. I mean this is something that doesn't happen too often in the history of music where you get four individuals with such amazing individual contributions and that are all playing together as one mind. And so this was overwhelming for me. But then I did of course get into all sorts of other people. I remember the Sonny Rollins "Live at the Village Vanguard" was one of the other albums I listened to a lot, and all the Jazz Messengers albums and then I went back and heard Bird. I remember one night I'm listening, I'm in bed listening to my radio, you know my parents think I'm asleep and I'm listening to the jazz station. And they played the "Live at Massey Hall" album. And I just about fell out of bed. That was the first time I heard Bird. And I said, "This is how – he plays the way I feel when I play is how this guy plays." It's like wow. So Charlie Parker, still, there's nobody that sounds like Bird.

MR: You just made me think of something I heard you say in a – I don't know if it was in an interview but, so I'm going to quote you. It says, "People may think – it looks like we're in a trance when we're playing, 'cause we are."

HL: Yeah, yeah. Sort of you're in the world but you're not really in the world. We're in our musical world you know, a musical universe where we're grabbing ideas from wherever the hell they come from, but it's also the tremendous amount of time and energy that we put in to learning how to play over the changes. I mean this is something that the general public has no idea – they think oh jazz it must be really easy, they're not reading music, and all this kind of stuff.

MR: Yeah. "Just play what you want."

HL: Yeah. And they come up to you and start talking to you while you're playing as if, like, come on. You have no idea what we're doing up here.

MR: I wanted to ask you about a video that I could only find once. It was very interesting because you were playing – it might even have been not in an established band – but you had an extended solo and after the fact you were talking about what you were doing. And you were saying, "Okay listen to this now I'm doing this scale in arpeggios," or "I'm playing a little blues lick here" and at one point you quoted another song and it was interesting because it was like your own narration of what you were doing. Do you remember this video?

HL: No. No.

MR: Like a lot of musicians, "No I don't remember doing that" but –

HL: Oh yeah that wedding you played with me forty years ago, I'm sure I was there but I don't remember. No I have so many videos out and I film so many things at my house

that are actually on my YouTube channel and I'm actually very proud of it. But that particular one – if you showed it to me I'm sure that I would remember it.

MR: Well what made me think and wonder, when you were doing these things you were describing after the fact, how conscious of them were you doing in real time? In other words what do you think about, are you intentionally "I'm going to play this now" you know in a split second and you do?

HL: Oh I think I know what you're talking about, yes. This is something – I put up a video recently. My wife said, "Hey why don't you narrate your solo?"

MR: That's it.

HL: Yeah we put up captions. And yeah, well all of that stuff is going on – the mind operates on many, and the spirit operates on many different levels when you're playing. And a lot of it is interacting with the people you're playing with. And I'm always – I think the fact that I'm a pianist, when I'm playing harmonica I really interact with the rhythm section in a way that's very, very direct and personal because I was a rhythm section player before I was a wind instrument player. So I'm very, very aware of rhythmic interplay. And also I listen to like every note that everyone else is playing. Always. I'm aware of all the like bass players' bass lines. I know what they're doing. And if I close my eyes I can see what the piano player is doing and see his hands, and that kind of stuff. So that's one level of what's going on. And the other level is how I'm interacting with that and the structure of the tune, if it's a tune with changes. You know? And so oh yeah, I'm very conscious of these kind of mathematical things as I'm doing them. But sometimes there are things I've worked on, like I remember I was playing triplets in fours – it's just something that's like feeling but I stepped back from it at a certain point and said, "Oh yeah I'm playing instead of [scats] I'm going [scats]" you know that kind of thing. And I work on these things. I mean I just work on so much stuff and rhythmic ratios. If I'm playing a tune that's like an ostinato, this tune that I wrote that we do in the Flecktones called "Sweet Pomegranates." It's an ostinato in six and it's in G sharp minor, an ostinato pattern in the left hand that I play the whole time with – I can't demonstrate it in the air but so I figured out how to play in five against that six, and in seven against that six, and nine against it and eleven against it. And I started gradually working it into my solos live at a certain point, inspired by Indian music really, where they do stuff like that all the time. And so yeah there's a certain amount of calculation in my playing, and the interaction, and also sometimes just going for it, just the shapes of intervals. Just almost like a line drawing you know. Because intervals have shapes. And if people just learn how to play jazz by learning your modes and your scales, I mean that's cool. That's sort of a reference framework. But to make a real artistic statement there's way more to it than just what are the correct notes and the relationship of those notes to the harmonic framework. There's

the shape of what you're doing. So I'm very conscious of that, and building tension in a solo. And if I'm playing live trying to engage the audience too. Reach out to them. Because I feel lucky to be able to have an audience you know. And so I want to give them back like as much as I possibly can. I want to take them on a journey you know.

MR: Well said. The piano and harmonica in my mind are very different for at least one reason, when you're playing the piano you can see the notes you're playing.

HL: Yes.

MR: When you're playing the harmonica, do you always know what notes you're playing?

HL: Yes. I visualize the harmonica as a piano keyboard. Since the harmonica is totally invisible when you play it – I mean you pick it up, you look at it, and it's got a bunch of these little holes – the holes don't tell you much. And as soon as you put it in your mouth it's gone anyway. So when I first started playing, when I was 18, and I was playing in that Northwestern jazz band and learning what thirteenth chords were and everything like that, which I didn't know before, it was like what the hell is this? And reading all these Thad Jones arrangements and, you know, all that kind of stuff, and Brookmeyer charts and all these things that were like oooo what is this? That was when I was just starting to play the harmonica and playing my first blues licks. And then I wanted the harmonica to come up to the level of what I was doing on piano. So I'm, you know I'm playing with my eyes closed and like "What am I seeing, what am I seeing?" And after a while I realized I was seeing the piano keyboard as well as shapes and colors. So kind of all of the above. But it got to be more and more like a piano, which is how I eventually ended up playing a lot of simultaneous piano and harmonica. Because it's one instrument.

MR: I just realized something. You just answered my question by saying that. Because I saw some of your videos where you were playing unison piano and harmonica lines.

HL: Yes.

MR: So you obviously know – you know that question was sort of I guess I'm thinking when you really are wailing on the harmonica, I was thinking to myself, "Does he know all the pitches actually?"

HL: Yes.

MR: Yeah. Okay.

HL: And you know I also used to play sax. I played tenor, alto, soprano, and flute. And that was one of the things – I talk about this in the book that one of the other ways that I learned about music was learning music through the instruments. You know. And I just, after I learned harmonica, and you know after about oh I don't know, three or four months of playing harmonica, that's when I figured out how to play the chromatic scale on it which nobody had ever done on the diatonic before. And that's a long story. But I started sounding very good and playing in all different keys on one, and not just the

standard blues stuff. And then I thought well maybe I could learn some other instruments and of course Coltrane, like I said, was like a saint to me. You know. It's like gee if I could learn how to play the saxophone, wow. That would be like a sacred instrument that I could actually learn how to play it. So someone lent me a horn and I started to learn how to play that when I was 19. And then the same thing happened with other instruments. And I was never a great saxophone player but I learned so much about the workings of the horn and I got the Sigurd Rascher book you know, *Top Tones*.

MR: Yes I have it.

HL: I'm sure you do. And you know the whole way that the overtone series works through the horn and it's not a linear instrument, and then listening to Coltrane with that knowledge was like oh my God, that's what he's doing, and hearing all the stuff Pharoah Sanders and Albert Ayler were doing and all that stuff. Like I started understanding it from the inside out and not just having it be this sort of mind-blowing thing that I didn't – that was just impressions. I was understanding it. And the same thing happened with all sorts of other string instruments I learned how to play and percussion instruments. So my learning process has been very multi-faceted. And at the same time as that was happening in the early and mid-'70s I started getting into quote world music before it had a name. I was just fascinated – actually Coltrane, believe it or not – was the impetus for that. There was this one tune and I know you know this tune, it was from that Prestige album called "The Last Train" where he played "Lover" at like 500 miles an hour. Have you heard that recording?

MR: Yes.

HL: It's unbelievable. And there's this blues called "By the Numbers." Red Garland plays like the most amazing blues jazz piano solos. Like perfect and beautiful. And Coltrane comes in on his solo and plays this one little figure [scats] it's like a little trill [scats]. It's obviously not jazz. It's obviously from another culture. He was invoking another world and that piqued my curiosity. And that one little figure he played led me to explore Middle Eastern music and Eastern European music and then eventually African music and Indonesian and Balinese Gamelan and Indian music and like I didn't own a TV for about six years. I got sort of disgusted with American pop culture in the '70s and polyester clothes and all that stuff. And I just got into the roots of music. You know? Like what is underlying things. You know I just took a deep dive into it and bought as many albums as I could and took out records from the Evanston Library and recorded them onto a reel to reel tape recorder and just listened over and over again, and went to as many concerts of world music, ethnic music – whatever you want to call it – as I could. Yeah. So yeah.

MR: That leads me to – this could be a Name that Tune or blindfold test.

HL: Okay.

MR: So tell me what –

[audio interlude]

HL: Oh, my concerto. Yeah.

MR: It's beautiful.

HL: Oh thank you.

MR: I became stuck with it. I had to keep playing it. And one of my own parameters about writing music is a goal of when it's over people will have part of it in their head. And that certainly applied here. The other thing that struck me was every time you played the harmonica in unison with various instruments it's like a new tone color was invented.

HL: Mmm. Mmm. Mmm.

MR: And that's like a real advantage, right? Like you've got this sort of built-in new sound every once in a while because as far as I know no one else is doing this exact thing.

HL: Not really. It's a funny thing how that concerto came about but I wrote it as a commission for an orchestra in Chicago. And I never studied composition, I never studied orchestration. And I just had to do it myself. And so I did. I wrote it out in pencil and then I gave it to a copyist and they made parts and made a score and everything. And the first time I performed it I was kind of terrified in certain ways because I also left room for myself to improvise in each movement. The first movement has a big cadenza, and the second movement I actually blow over those changes of that melody that you were playing. And the third movement also has a section that I left myself room to improvise over what are basically the changes of the Paganini solo violin "Caprice #24." Because you know in getting into classical music, which I really got deeply into for a while right around when I was writing this piece and studying the lives of the composers, all those guys were jazz musicians. They were all improvisers. Every last one of them was an improviser. But if you wanted people to hear your solos you had to write them down. I mean it's like a fact. Beethoven could improvise a fucking sonata. He did that for someone once and they thought he was lying. He just improvised it. Bach, you could whistle him a tune and he could improvise on it for an hour and a half. He could improvise fugues and canons and stuff. I mean all these guys were just – the improvisational element in classical music had to be written down, but they all left room for cadenzas and concertos they wrote for themselves, and they wrote for others too. And so I thought well of course I have to leave some room to blow. And I mean there are stories about Mozart taking requests from audiences in concerts. Like, "Play that aria from your opera." And he'd sit down and if he was in a real good mood he would just improvise something. And if he liked it he'd go home and write it out.

MR: He'd remember it, yeah.

HL: It's like yeah, I mean all those guys. They had just colossal brain power and colossal ears and you know we're spoiled because jazz spread through sound, through sound reproduction. And everyone said, "Oh let's get the latest Bird album, let's get the latest Coltrane album, let's listen to this and figure this out." Back then there were no albums. I mean you had to go hear someone play or get a score and study it. And that's what all those guys did. They all studied scores and Bach, I think he walked for like two weeks to hear this one organist play – I can't remember the story. But yeah. I mean they were much more similar to us than different. And classical music just got kind of fossilized in a certain way because the repertoire started growing so huge that classical musicians, the idea of improvising was like yeah, just figure out how to play Schoenberg and Tchaikovsky and Brahms and Bach and Vivaldi, all the things that you had to do if you're in an orchestra or a string quartet, when do you have time to improvise? You know? And so the classical players who back in the day, they were improvising all the time and the keyboard players like Bach would write out those figured bass keyboard parts, and all it was, it was the bass line and the changes.

MR: Yeah. He was writing chord changes.

HL: And of course all these keyboard players knew how to do that because that's what you did. Like give us a lead sheet, yeah. I'd much rather see a lead sheet than someone write out chord voicings, I'd be sitting there going [grunts] and getting behind. So they were way more similar to us than they were different. And so I try to have some of that spirit in my concerto you know.

MR: Where did the initial – sometimes you can't answer these kind of questions but the melodies, where do they come from?

HL: That's a really good question. I have no idea, man. Music – I think music exists in its own place and we grab things out of it. I really believe that. Because we don't invent them. Some of it is just imitation, a lot of it actually. Because like I said, you know I listen, I'm listening constantly. I'm just all the time listening and turning other people on to like, "Listen to this." I'm like one of those guys. "Did you ever hear this?" You know, that kind of stuff. But I don't know, I think they reside in a place and we just grab them.

MR: Yeah.

HL: I really think so.

MR: All right let me try another one here.

[audio interlude]

HL: "Aha."

MR: "Aha." I like that title by the way.

HL: Yeah. I wrote that a while ago. That was inspired by playing with Paquito and that's who I wrote it for. That's something he used to say, "Aha!" You know?

MR: I see.

HL: Yeah and that has some changes. I really don't like quote standard changes. If I can write something that's a little bit twisted you know, just something that sounds smooth and melodic but when you play it it's like ooh, ooh, there's a little corner you've got to go around here, and that tune is very much like that. And of course I wrote it on piano and I had to figure out how to play it on harmonica. That's -- most of my writing happens on piano. It's only been in the last, well I guess the last twenty or thirty years that I can write on harmonica at all. For the first like twenty years that I played the harmonica I didn't really write on harmonica.

MR: Do you think the most challenging musical situations that you've been in over the years, have they mostly been self-imposed? By that I mean well you're playing with Bela and wow this is tricky music. But my observation is that you invent your own challenges.

HL: Yeah. I mean if you get with someone who's like a kindred spirit, I mean Bela and I very much so, both playing very unstandard things on our instruments, you know, especially the harmonica and the banjo. The piano is another thing. And so I love a challenge as long as I can rise to the challenge. If the challenge is beyond me I say like let someone else play the gig. But if it's something I feel I can really sink my teeth into it's like man, yeah, let's go for it, let's do this tune that has all these really odd changes in it and strange rhythmic modulations. Yeah it's just like food you know. You grow as a human being from learning how to play all this stuff. I mean I've been listening to a bunch of Mingus lately. And I think that the guys who played with him, it was the same thing. The stuff he wrote was just so, like so wild and so emotionally spontaneous. And the fact that he could notate it all. And you know you play music like this, it transforms you you know? And it gives you a vocabulary that you wouldn't have had before you played this music. And then there's the other part of the question that you asked, it really relates directly to touring. Because I think that a musician really grows from touring and having to play similar material night after night after night and trying to remain creative but also stay within the music is sort of those two tensions for someone like me who's always trying to find new things and also remaining faithful to the music. It's the way you grow. It accelerates the learning process.

MR: Can you think of a circumstance that happened to you, or you just mentioned that if you didn't feel you could rise to a challenge you would suggest someone else do it. What kind of situation might that be?

HL: Something where they're asking me to read something on piano that a classical musician could read, and I'm looking at it going man, I can't read all this stuff. You know. If you want me, if there's some reading and some soloing involved yeah cool. But if you're asking me to play stuff that would just take me way too long to learn, because my reading

has never been up to the level of my ability to improvise. I mean it's not terrible – I'm a pretty good reader – but like yeah, that kind of thing.

MR: Did you have piano teachers who – did you stray from the compositions you were supposed to be playing during lessons and have piano teachers saying like, "What are you doing there? You can't do that."

HL: Oh yes. Because when I was a kid and studying at Manhattan School you know they had these student concerts. And so a lot of us would be assigned the same pieces. And you know I would hear the stuff that the other kids played. And I'd get to a passage in a piece that I'd heard before and go, "God, this is hard to read, I think it goes like this." You know. So I would never play wrong notes, but I would be playing over the correct changes but I would you know, have my own little inner voicings, my own little melodies or something. And my teacher would go, "Wait a minute, it doesn't sound wrong but that's not Schubert" you know that kind of thing. It was exasperating to my teacher, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Well the fact that you recognized the changes that Schubert was using I think is significant anyway.

HL: Oh yeah. I mean I just had an innate sense of harmony. But you know everyone is born with certain abilities and then it's just a matter of okay, if you're going to try to get in the pond with the big boys, all right, it's great that you can do this and you can do that, but can you play "All the Things You Are" in all twelve keys? In any tempo? I mean I know Bird kicked George Shearing's ass one night. I heard that story. You know George Shearing came over from England and he's sitting there at some club on 52nd Street and he thinks he's, you know, the cat's meow. And Bird says, "All right, I heard about you, you know get up, let's play "All the Things You Are." And he said, "In B minor." It's like [counts off fast]. You know. And George Shearing went home with his tail between his legs and said, "Okay, now I see the level of these guys." Because this is what's frightening is the level that these guys with big names, what their level actually was. And this is what the general public has no idea, the ability to transpose anything into any key at the drop of a hat. And this is something I work on a lot. And as a jazz pianist of course, who you know I did play a number of gigs accompanying singers and it's like okay I want to play – this one singer used to do "Sophisticated Lady" in D. Okay? And so it's like I had to play "Sophisticated Lady" in D. I mean no rehearsals. Like okay, "Sophisticated Lady" in D. It's like okay. And your on-the-job training. It's like how am I going to think about this? Am I thinking like relative? Like functional harmony of like now I'm going to the 2-5 of the 4 or am I just like doing this organically. This is one of the main things that jazz musicians can do that average musicians don't know how to do is transpose. And I actually had training at that at Manhattan. They had us transpose things when I was studying classical piano. And even now I play Bach inventions, there's

a few that I've played for my whole life, the number 4 [scats] that one. I transposed it into all twelve keys. And I do it with my eyes closed and you know, all that kind of stuff. Because there's no cheating in music. I mean either you can or you can't do it. And then I have to slow down. Okay I know what it sounds like but my fingering sucks when I'm playing it in F sharp minor. I'm like, "What's the right fingering here?"

MR: Okay I've got – I've got one more for you –

[audio interlude]

HL: I can't recognize the tune but it's obviously Toots. Is it from that Brazilian project album or is it –

MR: You are absolutely correct. It's Toots with Quincy Jones from the album "Walking in Space."

HL: "Walking in Space." Yeah. Oh Quincy loved Toots. I mean, and I got to meet Toots and play with him a few times too. And of course you know he played the chromatic with the button on it. And was very intrigued and kind of like puzzled by like why I was playing chromatically on a diatonic. But we got along real well. And yeah Toots was a genius, a musical genius who just so happened to play the harmonica and give his gifts to the instrument. But the thing about him musically was that he started on accordion and he also saw the harmonica as a keyboard. Yeah. So I discovered that the first time we met and I sat in with him when I was in my – maybe I was 30, 31 or something like that, in Chicago. So yeah, he was an incredible, incredible musician, an amazing harmonica player. And for jazz chromatic playing for about 30 or 40 years nobody who played jazz on chromatic had their own personality because his was so strong. It took a long time before chromatic jazz players started sounding different. Like Gregoire Maret and people like that who just sounded like a guy playing a chromatic harmonica instead of sounding like Toots.

MR: Why did you not go in that direction with the chromatic harmonica?

HL: Well the reason why I started playing the harmonica was that my buddies and I in high school and we started with the rock bands and then we started playing blues, and I fell in love with the sound of the blues harmonica and all the Chicago guys, you know Paul Butterfield, James Cotton, Little Walter – that sound. And you can't get that sound on the chromatic. So you know once I discovered how to play chromatically on the diatonic harmonica I thought well why can't I take this instrument into the same places that, you know, sax players, trumpet players, I mean like pianists. You know I want to take this instrument as far as I can rather than say I'm going to give up here when the music gets to a certain point I'm going to stop this and play this. Because this instrument doesn't do the same thing that this instrument does. And this instrument doesn't exactly do what this one does either. So it was a choice. Because I know how to play the chromatic. I taught

myself how to play it in the early and mid-1970s when I was trying to get better at reading music on harmonica. Because I found it too difficult to read on this instrument while I was doing all of these manipulations with the inside of my mouth and all this stuff to get all the pitches. And gradually I became a very good reader on this. But yeah, this, the bluesy, soulfulness of this instrument, which is a total accident of design, is what appeals to me. Do you want me to explain how the [inaudible]

MR: You know the first time I saw on a date, it was a blues date, and I had never seen the harmonica. This particular player had a whole tacklebox full of these harps. And I was like holy cow, you have to have one for – you know they had to have one for every key.

HL: Yes.

MR: I guess you don't have to carry a tacklebox around with you?

HL: Well I do carry a bunch of different keys because well basically, and just for the sake of demonstrating, I'm just going to use the C harp. I mean it's not my favorite harmonica but it's the universal key of the white keys of the piano. And basically what the Germans did in the 1820s or 1830s or whenever this tuning system was figured out, this one probably came about in the 1850s. It's call the Richter tuning. And they tried to design this instrument so it could play the one and the five chord on the bottom [demonstrates], and the melody notes in the middle [demonstrates] and then to keep going until they ran out of notes up on the top. It's very precise. So they left out a bunch of notes in the first octave, to be able to just have the [demonstrates] that five chord [demonstrates] and in the middle [demonstrates] you have all the notes of the major scale. So basically the folk music played on this instrument, you know, [demonstrates] they could harmonize, that was the idea. It's like an autoharp. You have like the one and the five chord. And so if you play [demonstrates] if you reverse that breathing pattern and start on the inhale [demonstrates] you get the Mixolydian mode and you get a blues shuffle. And then, as if by magic, all these bent notes – am I distorting the mic at all?

MR: No, you're good.

[audio interlude]

HL: That stuff, the Germans had no idea they were designing that. Because what happens is, and I'm not going to get too geeky here, but you can bend the higher note on a hole down to just above the pitch of the lower note. And since they left out a whole bunch of notes on the bottom octave [demonstrates] you've got all that [demonstrates]. So you have almost the complete chromatic scale on the first octave, just [demonstrates]. There's a few things missing, and in the middle octave you get more notes – there's a bunch more notes missing that you can't get by bends. But I'm going to get – I'll explain a little more of that but basically what you have here is you have a modal instrument. So you can play in C major [demonstrates]; G Mixolydian [demonstrates] with bends, whatever; you can

play in D Dorian [demonstrates]; and you can play in A Aeolian [demonstrates] whoops I made that Dorian, sorry [demonstrates]; and you can play in E Phrygian [demonstrates]. So you can hear all these flavors that are in there. "Gee that doesn't sound like a harmonica." That's because 99 percent of the time you hear guys going [demonstrates]. They're only playing in what's called second position, which is Mixolydian mode with all the bends and stuff. And then you've got Locrian mode on the B [demonstrates]. So those are the modal positions. In the harmonica world they call them by numbers that correspond to the fifths of the circle of fifths. And of course I came along and figured out how to get the missing notes [demonstrates] with a thing called overblows and overdraws, and made it into a chromatic instrument. And I can play like pretty much anything in any key except I can't go [demonstrates] I can't do that in every key on one harmonica because that is like the innate structure of the instrument that allows you to do that. So if I want to play a traditional blues in D let's say, I'd need a G harmonica to play the Mixolydian mode you know. So anyway that's a little bit of the –

MR: Thank you for that.

HL: Harminology.

MR: I was wondering, I don't know why this occurred to me but there's a, you know a nice video of you with your, playing your concerto, I think it's with the Evanston Symphony.

HL: Oh yeah.

MR: I wondered, does he have a spare harmonica in his pocket?

HL: Oh, yeah. Because I mean that's why I carry, I usually carry like two or three in the keys that I use the most because sometimes they'll get clogged up or something will happen to it and so I can always reach over and grab another one. That particular concerto I compose it for – each movement is using a different key harmonica, for whatever reason I decided to do that. First movement uses a G, second movement an A, and the third movement a C. My new concerto that I just, that I'm going to premier in February, this one, it's called – I still forget the name of the damn thing – "Eastern European Harmonica and Piano Concerto for Single Soloist." This one I use a B flat harmonica for almost the whole piece except for the second movement because I like the B flat harmonica. And the second movement I do a bunch of simultaneous piano and harmonica playing and since the G harp is the first one I learned on, I see the G harp the most directly as a piano keyboard. So when I'm playing those things together usually I'm using a G harp.

MR: Yeah. How did you learn about the – all the things you need to know about ranges and what instruments can do well and not so well. Like basically orchestration. Did you teach yourself?

HL: Yeah. And just also from knowing how to play a lot of instruments, that kind of helps. You know I can play clarinet and flute and I know what the oboe is and I know what the range of trumpets are. I mean I've played with trumpet players for years, and trombone, and I know what these things sound like you know. I don't really write out of range. And I do play mandolin and my ex-girlfriend was a violinist, and so I know, I mean I'm a pretty good mandolin player so I'm not going to write unplayable things for strings. I mean I know how to write the correct double stops and all that stuff, and working a lot with Eugene Friesen, the great cellist within that band Trio Globo. It familiarized me with the cello on a very personal level, and I play some bass too so I understand bass. So learning the instruments really helped me with the orchestration, and going to a lot of live concerts of Chicago Symphony also helped me greatly. Before I wrote the concerto I wrote a chamber suite that's also on the same album that's in 1995, for oboe, flute, violin, viola, cello and me, and I really like that piece. I don't know if you've heard it but it's called "Harmonia Mundi" and it's really good. I'm very proud of it. And I also composed an oboe sonata about ten years ago which was just recorded by an oboist named Jared Hauser. Did a real nice job with it.

MR: Speaking of Trio Globo I wanted to compliment you on the tune "Steering by the Stars."

HL: Oh thank you.

MR: And I don't know if it put it in my head but I got this nautical images from that song.

HL: Absolutely. I was on the road with the Flecktones and I went to a bookstore and got out a book that I still remember the name of, my goodness. It was called *Song for Satawal* and it went into great detail about how Polynesians navigated these vast distances traversing the Pacific Ocean making star charts out of like cane and pebbles. And they would sight these stars through these charts and also feel the direction of the currents with their bodies as they sailed with no maps across hundreds and hundreds of miles of ocean. And this inspired me to write "Steering by the Stars." You nailed it. And I wrote it, I used a carry a little keyboard with me and we were staying in a little like bunch of cabins on the Pacific Ocean near San Diego and I wrote that in my hotel room there. And it took quite a few years for me to – well I guess, yeah, we recorded that in like maybe 2008 or something like that. It took almost fifteen years to record that after I wrote it. Yeah. Wow.

MR: These projects that you do, do you get the idea and then look for the people, or do you hear other musicians who inspire the idea?

HL: Both. Definitely. I mean with Trio Globo, Gene and Glen are very inspiring players and composers, and so that group is a very – it's like a group of three equals and we all are inspired by each other and write things for each other. And then sometimes I just, you know, write a tune and say, "Could you guys do this?" And sometimes they say no and

sometimes they say yes. And whenever they say yes it ends up sounding way better than anything I could have imagined.

MR: It makes me think of – can you recall the first time, with your first concerto, that first rehearsal and how you felt when you heard it. Did it sound – were you surprised?

HL: Yeah I was going to say you know I wrote with pencil. I didn't have midi, or I wasn't using Finale, it was just all in my head. I just wrote at the piano and on the harmonica and at my kitchen table and hotel rooms. So yeah, I was surprised and actually, there were certain parts of the piece that actually moved me emotionally and I kind of got choked up. It was like, "Okay Howard, come on man, you know, you can't be moved by your own music, you have to concentrate here and play." But that was the biggest surprise was being moved by what I had written, that it really affected me emotionally. Yeah. So this new one, I don't know what's going to happen. Because it's almost all in odd time meters. It's inspired by Bulgarian and Macedonian, Romanian and Greek music. There's a lot of things in five and seven and nine and eleven. I didn't go any higher than eleven. Like Spinal Tap you know?

MR: I just read a book about Spinal Tap.

HL: Oh Harry Shearer is a friend of mine.

MR: Oh no kidding?

HL: We played a bunch of gigs together. He's a very good musician. He writes really interesting tunes, like with very unstandard changes in them. It's like whoa. Very interesting guy and a huge music head. I mean just – I think I'm going to see him in New Orleans when the Flecktones play our last show.

MR: Yeah. We are a fan of his show on the radio. But it's interesting, you said because you wrote the first concerto pre-Finale, that you hadn't really heard it. But Finale and those things can also affect you like if you have decent playback by the time you're done you've heard this thing hundreds of times. And it's been my experience – I'm talking mostly about big band charts, that I hear it played by live people and sometimes there's a moment of disappointment, probably because it's not perfectly in tune like Finale, right? And then of course you get used to it and it's better because real people are playing it.

HL: Yeah. Well I mean of course, depending on the quality of the orchestra and of the conductor, there have been, like I said I performed this thing probably 35 times, and certain performances stand out in my mind. It's like an absolute synergy between me and the conductor and the orchestra, where it's like thrilling; and other ones were like, kind of like dragging a mule. "Come on guys!" One of the most surprising performances of it that I ever did was Hohner, you know they're headquartered in Germany in Bavaria in a little town called Trossingen and I've worked with Hohner for years now. They have an accordion orchestra and I performed my concerto with the accordion orchestra twice, or

maybe three times. And the third time it was amazing. Because they knew the piece, the conductor was really great, and I knew a lot of these people and it just had a beautiful vibe. It was just – yeah playing, performing and playing with the Evanston Symphony was special too because I live here and the hall was sold out, I knew some of the people in the orchestra. It was a very special feeling. And the conductor is a really good jazz pianist. And we did an encore, it was a Valentine's Day concert. We did an encore just playing "My Funny Valentine," me and him. You should look that up. It's really good. We just like – it was kind of magical. And so yeah, and also I have to say that second movement, it's kind of an earworm. I've always been drawn to melody you know. I can hear and write all kinds of abstract stuff but somehow I'm more deeply committed to something that's a memorable melody. That to me is like a statement. It's like a speech. You're really saying something. You know? So when I played it in Prague I recorded it, the professional recording is with the Czech National Symphony Orchestra, and I recorded it with them in Prague and then we did it in concert at this beautiful concert hall they have called the Rudolfinum, and I just felt like I had written that movement for those people in that city. It just felt like okay, this is where this second movement lives. It's right here in Prague. And the audience really loved the performance. I had to do two or three solo encores after I did the concerto.

MR: Well you've come a long way since spending $2.25 on your first harmonica.

HL: I hope so yeah. They're much more expensive, that's how long –

MR: I've really enjoyed this conversation, Howard, and wish you the best with your book.

HL: Thanks. And the name of the book, I forgot to say what the name of the book is, what is it – oh it's called *I Speak Music, Stories from my Improbable Life*. That's what it's called.

MR: Titles are not always easy things, but that's a good one.

HL: Yeah. And it's available online on Amazon and eventually on many more platforms. Yeah. It's been an interesting time the last few years doing these major projects interspersed with intense tours and live gigs and also with my own band. We might be coming to the Rochester Jazz Festival too, the Howard Levy Four.

MR: Oh good. I'll definitely be there for that.

HL: I sure hope so anyway.

MR: Yeah. A pleasure.

HL: All right.

MR: I'll just pause our recording and we'll say our good-byes.

HL: Okay.

MR: Thank you.